PHOTO BY **HARDIK CHHABRA**



THE GREAT JOB SQUEEZE

1. YOUTH UNEMPLOYMENT IN 2025 WAS THREE TIMES THE OVERALL UNEMPLOYMENT RATE
2. LACK OF ADEQUATE JOBS AND APPROPRIATE WAGES IS TURNING INTO A CHALLENGE
3. PRIVATE SECTOR JOBS NOT ENOUGH TO MEET DEMAND, EMPLOYERS SEEK BETTER SKILLS
4. MILLIONS OF GOVERNMENT POSTS REMAIN VACANT; OUTSOURCING OF JOBS RAMPANT, EXAMS CANCELLED

tests expressing dissatisfaction with the current state of affairs —by industrial workers in the Delhi-NCR belt over low wages and poor working conditions, then by students protesting the cancellation of the NEET exam, and again in states like Jharkhand and Bihar over irregularities in recruitment exams for state administrative services.

Alakh N. Sharma, Director, Institute for Human Development, says jobs and wages are not keeping pace with economic growth. "Unemployment is a problem for the youth, especially in the educated segment in urban areas. In rural areas, the young educated can still report themselves as being employed by working part time in agriculture or a family enterprise, but for the urban, educated youth, there are few such avenues," he says.

Sharma's prognosis is backed by data from the 2025 PLFS report. People with secondary and above education reported the highest unemployment rates among all cohorts at 6.5% in 2025 versus 0.3% for persons who were not literate. Even those with coveted degrees such as engineering and MBA are struggling to find jobs.

HIGHER EDUCATION ISN'T HELPING

Across the country, engineers and management graduates are finding that their degree may open the door to the job market, but it doesn't guarantee an offer. Students graduating from average MBA colleges say they are increasingly finding themselves caught between a degree and the skills that recruiters demand.

Take Ayush Negi. The 24-year-old completed his MBA from a university in Rishikesh, focusing largely on earning the degree, with little guidance on the practical